MACQUARIE University

2026 | Session 1 – COMP2150: Game Design

Assessment Task 3: Tabletop Game Design

Submission details	
Due Date	23:55, 24/05/2026, Week 11
Weighting	Assessment will be marked out of a total of 100 marks. This assessment will contribute to 30% of overall unit grade.
Time to complete	This assessment will take approximately 34 hours to complete. Additional time will be given in practicals and SGTAs for this task.
Length & Format	The assignment involves three deliverables: • A playingcards.io file of your (.pcio file) tabletop game, fully playable, with a meaningful round of gameplay being 15 minutes (see task details for more info). This file is submitted by the group. • A single document (pdf) that includes game instructions, design documentation and playtesting info. This document has a word count of ~5000 words. See task description and template file for more info. This file is submitted by the group. • Completing of the team evaluation form on iLearn. This is completed individually.
Late Penalties	Standard late penalty applies.
How to Submit	Submit your group report and game file to iLearn. Only one group member needs to submit. Once this is done, each group member must fill out the team evaluation form, accessible by clicking the assignment upload link.
Return of Assessment Grade & Feedback	Grades and feedback will be returned after mark finalisation via iLearn.
Purpose	As a team, you will design and implement a tabletop game based on a design brief, demonstrating an understanding of advanced game design principles. You will submit design documentation, justifying design decisions. You must evaluate the game through a program of playtesting to determine whether it meets your goals, and iterate accordingly.
Learning Outcomes Assessed	ULO1: Apply the process of iterative, player-centric game design to produce a range of low-to-high fidelity game prototypes. ULO3: Employ level and system design theories to prototype games using relevant digital tools. ULO4: Collaborate with fellow designers to conceptualise game experiences and craft game mechanics to facilitate them. ULO5: Communicate design goals and reasoning through appropriate documentation. ULO6: Evaluate game prototypes using formal playtesting methods and apply findings to iterate on their design.
Skills assessed	Using the theory, processes and methods explored in Lectures, SGTAs and Pracs, this task allows you to demonstrate: 1. Your collaboration skills. 2. Your ability to design meaningful gameplay experiences.

	3. Your understanding of how dynamics emerge from intentional mechanics design. 4. Your ability to craft, conduct and learn from external playtesting.
How will this task be assessed?	Teams will be given a group mark based on the submitted game and documentation. This mark will then be modified up or down based on team evaluation results and any other available evidence. Where discrepancies are found, staff may reach out to students for more clarity around contributions and grievances. For example: *A team of four students receives a 70/100 for their assignment.* *Team Evaluation reveals one team member did not contribute to the project at all. This team member's mark is modified from 70 to 0 after investigation.* *Another team member was reported to have done extra work, and appears to have done the vast majority of mechanic design, which is also the strongest part of the task. This student's mark is boosted to 90 after investigation.* *The other two group members had equal contributions, and can reasonably be seen to have put in the amount of work that the final game is reflective of. They both receive the base mark of 70.*
Use of AI	Open. Generative AI may be used in this assignment as part of the design process, to create art for cards, and to provide feedback on your writing. However, all writing should be your own and you are expected to read all content to verify its reliability. Falsified playtesting data created or modified by Generative AI will be taken seriously.
Short automated extensions	Yes

Task overview

For this assessment, you will work in groups to create a digital tabletop card game fitting a defined spec, following prototyping and playtesting practices and documenting your game.

Task details / specific instructions

You and your team are **game designers** working for a **tabletop game publisher.** You have been given the following design brief:

We're looking for new titles to put into production. We want your team to design a table-top card game that focuses on **multiplayer interaction** through **manipulating a resource economy.** The player should be provided with game dynamics that create **interesting choices** and a **rich space for strategies**. We'll be evaluating these games for full production as https://playingcards.io files, and we also need to see a **game design document** and **playtesting data.** We're open to whatever theme and genre you'd like, but the game must target the following experience goals:

Fellowship: The game should encourage inter-player interaction. It may be competitive, co-operative, team-based or any other multiplayer configuration.
Challenge: The game should involve some elements of social skill, and may also include other skills.
Drama: The game should present the players with interesting choices.

Additionally, the game must meet the following requirements:

1. It **must** use a custom deck of cards you have designed. Card template files are available on iLearn.

2. The number of players **must** be 3-4. This means that a minimum of three players is required for meaningful gameplay, and a maximum of four can play.

3. It **must** involve at least two different resources with distinct properties.

4. A meaningful round of gameplay **must** be reliably completable within 15 minutes. A meaningful round means all the game's design features have been experienced.

5. You **may** use any of the standard resources found in the playingcards.io tool. Remember that any of the resources used in your submission will also need to be representable in your physical prototypes for playtesting.

To achieve this, you'll be creating and testing paper prototypes of your game (both in and out of class), as well as creating a final version using https://playingcards.io.

Note: when marking your game, the markers will need to familiarise themselves with the rules before playing. Please keep this in mind and design your rules to be easy to interpret, utilise and execute.

Playtesting

You are required to plan and carry out at least three major playtests for your game as part of an iterative design approach. At least one of these playtests must be conducted using your physical prototype.

Each playtest should have a unique design targeted at answering important design questions, to help you iterate on and improve your game. Each playtest should also collect data across multiple sessions (with different participants for each session), to ensure the answers to these questions are not biased by a limited sample. We must see evidence of these playtests being intentionally designed as well as the data collected from running them. Further detail is within the documentation report.

Although a minimum of two distinct groups/sessions of the game are required for each of your three major playtests for a passing mark on the related rubric, it is unlikely this will give you enough data to meaningfully answer your design questions. We recommend four distinct external groups/sessions per major playtest to ensure you capture the required data.

Further details

Game

The final game submission should be a "table set-up" version of your game complete with player seats, decks and any necessary tokens or dice created using playingcards.io. Details on how to use playingcards.io will be introduced to you throughout the practicals, with further support available through iLearn. Please reach out to the unit convenors with any questions, and we will endeavour to provide you with resources.

Instructions for Play

Your documentation will include instructions for play. These do not count towards your wordcount, and are custom-designed, including required resources, set-up and rules. You should consider your instructions for play as an extension of your game, and an opportunity to help set the fiction and world of your game, as well as provide a meaningful interface for the players.

Design Document
Your design document is your opportunity to discuss and justify your game design decisions. See the template for required sections and recommended word counts.

Playtesting Report
Your playtesting report is responsible for documenting and evidencing that playtesting took place. You will need to include the design and results from **at least three distinct playtests.** See the template for required sections and recommended word counts.

Appendix
This section is for any necessary appendices for your game, including:
1. your custom deck of cards along with any other printouts required to play the game.
2. playtesting results data and playtesting instruments/resources.
3. any other design artefacts/resources you wish to include that weren't integrated into the rest of the report.

Your appendices do not count to your word count.

Individual Peer Assessment
Filling out the team evaluation form is an important tool for us to properly individualise marks. It is also your opportunity to tell your side of the story, which we will take into account. Do so with consideration and professionalism, but also be transparent as to how the group operated.

Planning and Team Expectations
To prepare for this assessment, it is important to have a planning discussion with your team about what each member's contribution to the required assessment tasks will be, and the quality of work that is expected (including the grade that you are aiming for). It isn't always necessary for every group member to contribute to all tasks equally. What is more important is setting expectations and standards together, and working towards those outcomes.

Quality Criteria

A high-quality submission is:
- A well set-up game ready to play.
- A game with a clear set of rules that are easy to understand.
- Focuses on player experience as specified in the design brief.
- Utilises the constraints of the assignment to its advantage.
- Shows evidence of the team having carried out intentional playtesting, and iterated on the game's design based on this data.
- Directly meets task requirements and demonstrates learning outcomes.

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Your group mark will be determined against the below rubric, with adjustments then made with respect to team evaluation and other evidence. Each component is equally weighted.

Assessment Component	Outstanding **High Distinction** (100%-85%)	Advanced **Distinction** (84%-75%)	Proficient **Credit** (74%-65%)	Functional **Pass** (64%-50%)	Developing **Fail** (49%-0%)
Game Design	Game design capitalises on constraints with finely-tuned mechanics that produce engaging dynamics and expertly balanced interesting choices. Player experience goals are frequently and meaningfully satisfied. The game's form and fiction has excellent readability and usability and frequently approaches a professional level of clarity and creativity.	Game design capitalises on constraints with well-tuned mechanics that produce engaging dynamics and finely balanced interesting choices. Player experience goals frequently satisfied. The game's form and fiction has great readability and usability, excelling in either clarity or creativity.	Game design satisfies all constraints, with systems reliably producing engaging dynamics and well-balanced interesting choices. Some satisfaction of all required player experience goals. The game's form and fiction provides good readability and a high level of clarity or creativity.	The game's design satisfies all constraints with minor violations, and systems have the potential to produce engaging dynamics with some interesting choices. Some satisfaction of most required player experience goals. The game's form and fiction provides fair readability but may show minor issues with clarity or metaphor application.	The game's design may not clearly satisfy constraints, or may miss required components. Systems may not reliably produce dynamics or have limited opportunities for interesting choices. Mechanical issues that should have been fixed through playtesting are present. Form and fiction has problems with readability or usability, clarity or dissonant metaphor.
Game Communication	Documentation expertly encapsulates the group's game design, mobilising relevant theory to justify design decisions and showing significant depth of insight thorough a detailed understanding of the game, its mechanics, interesting decisions, dynamics and player experience. Production processes and tools are concretely outlined, with convincing evidence of forward planning. Reflections are insightful, relevant and actionable for future projects.	Documentation soundly encapsulates the group's game design, relying on relevant theory to justify design decisions and showing some insight into and a detailed understanding of the game, its mechanics, interesting decisions, dynamics and player experience. Production processes and tools are clearly outlined, with strong evidence of forward planning. Reflections are considered and relevant to future projects.	Documentation does a good job encapsulating the group's game design, often referencing relevant theory to justify design decisions and showing a strong understanding of the game, its mechanics, interesting decisions, dynamics and player experience. Production processes and tools are outlined, with good evidence of forward planning. Reflections are grounded and relevant to future projects.	Documentation satisfactorily encapsulating the group's game design, sometimes referencing relevant theory to justify design decisions and showing a good understanding of the game, its mechanics, interesting decisions, dynamics and player experience. Production processes and/or tools are outlined, with some evidence of forward planning. Reflections are a genuine attempt at relevance to future projects.	Documentation fails to encapsulate or effectively communicate the group's game design. Design decisions are poorly justified, overly vague or not grounded in relevant theory, often showing poor understanding of the game, its mechanics, interesting decisions, dynamics or player experience. Reflection on production processes is missing important details, shows little to no evidence of planning, or fails to genuinely reflect on approaches.

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Playtesting Design	The design of the playtests (including the design questions, prototype, selected sample, chosen methods, and implemented procedure and instruments) follows best practice and is highly ambitious and expertly aligned with the group's game design considerations, with considered mixed-methods testing of both the analog and digital version of the game.	The design of the playtests (including the design questions, prototype, selected sample, chosen methods, and implemented procedure and instruments) follows good practice and is ambitious and has great alignment with the group's game design considerations, with appropriate mixed-methods testing of both the analog and digital version of the game.	The design of the playtests (including the design questions, prototype, selected sample, chosen methods, and implemented procedure and instruments) largely follows good practice and has good alignment with the group's game design considerations, with some mixed-methods testing of both the analog and digital version of the game.	The design of the playtests (including the design questions, prototype, selected sample, chosen methods, and implemented procedure and instruments) follows some elements of good practice and has a satisfactory alignment with the group's game design considerations, with tests designed for both the analog and digital version of the game.	The presented playtests suffer from significant design or implementation errors, with major required elements missing, unclear, or showing very poor alignment with the playtesting needs of the group's game.
Playtesting Execution	Clear and convincing evidence of an extensive program of playtesting to inform iterative design, with at least three unique playtest designs executed externally with four or more sessions each. All required sections/elements clear and complete, including copies of raw results and instrument templates in the appendices. Clear evidence of thoughtful application of playtesting results across iterations.	Clear evidence of an ambitious program of playtesting to inform iterative design, with at least three unique playtest designs executed externally with three or more sessions each. All required sections/elements clear and complete, including copies of raw results and instrument templates in the appendices. Clear evidence of application of playtesting results across iterations.	Ample evidence of a targeted program of playtesting to inform iterative design, with at least three customised playtest designs executed externally with two or more sessions each. All required sections/elements complete, including copies of raw results and instrument templates in the appendices. Evidence of playtesting results contributing to iteration.	Some evidence of a program of external playtesting to inform iterative design, with at least three customised playtest designs executed with two or more sessions each. Almost all required sections/elements complete, including some examples of raw results and instrument templates in the appendices. Playtesting results appear to have contributed to iteration, but not always thoughtfully applied.	Significant sections of the report may be unclear or missing, with limited or inconsistent evidence indicating fewer than three external tests may have been conducted, or that some results may not be genuine. Little evidence of playtesting influencing iteration.